An unusual ARMY of 80 assembled in a studio in Mumbai on July 13. All clad in purple, they screamed what seemed to be the names of their deities: "Kim Namjoon! Kim Seokjin! Min Yoongi! Jung Hoseok! Park Jimin! Kim Taehyung! Jeon Jungkook! BTS!" They were chanting the names of the seven members of the wildly popular Korean boy band, BTS or The Bangtan Boys. The occasion? The annual get-together of their devoted fanbase, which calls itself the ARMY, short for Adorable Representative M.C. for Youth. Among them were besties Vanessa Daniel, 33, and Diana D'Souza, 36, one a teacher and the other dayjobbing at a top corporate. Between bites of purple-frosted cupcakes, they shared what BTS means for them. "Emotionally, they offer me a lot of support," says Vanessa. Adds Diana: "I don't go to a therapist, I turn to them."

She has company. Today's hour of bonding over BTS comes courtesy organiser Ayushree Tari, founder of the Mumbai BTS fan club and owner of The Purple Door, a company named after the band's signature colour and logo. On Ayushree's left hand is a tattoo of her favourite BTS track 'Mikrocosmos'; on the right, a logo of their album *Love Yourself*. Also around was 19-year-old Sai Chikane, who is studying medicine in Vietnam but had flown down to Mumbai to dance to a K-Pop medley. Elsewhere, dance crew WEUNITE held a workshop for fans to hone their choreography—and their attitudes. With five BTS members having recently completed their mandatory military service in South Korea, the band will reunite in Spring 2026. For fans, the countdown has begun.

The BTS ARMY is just one happy ripple in the broader 'Hallyu' wave, a Chinese coinage for the global proliferation of South Korean popular culture that now has millions of Indians in its thrall. Korean music and soaps have long found a uniquely Indian audience, as have Korean films like *Train to Busan*, with filmmakers like Kim Ki-duk (*3 Iron*), Lee Chang-dong (*Poetry*, *Burning*), Park Chan-wook (*Oldboy*, *The Handmaiden*), Bong Joon Ho (*Memories of Murder*, *The Host*, *Parasite*) enjoying iconic status among cinephiles. Beyond entertainment, Indians have also acquired a taste for Korean food and beverage, and a yen for Korean beauty products. Blue Tokai café and Chaayos now have Korean cream cheese buns on their menu; McDonald's ran a Korea-inspired menu the other day with burgers glazed with the sweet and spicy *gochujang* sauce; Wagh Bakri tea lounge hosts a bubble tea carnival called 'Summer in



K-POP SOUND SENSATIONS

1. *BTS (The Bangtan Boys):* Insanely popular 7-member boy band, and the first K-Pop act to get Grammy nomination

2. *BLACKPINK:* One of Korea's leading girl bands, known for their fashion as much as music

3. (L-R) *IU:* Popular singer cum actress
***PSY:* The man who put K-Pop on the world map with 'Gangnam Style'**
***BoA:* A veteran idol who has popularised K-Pop in Japan and beyond**
***G-Dragon:* A rapper who has served vas inspiration to artists like BTS, Seventeen and Got7**

4. *EXO:* A boy band, two of whose members have performed in India



Photographs: Getty Images & AFP